

A NEW APPEAL Kishor at a rally in Kaimur district during his Bihar Badlav Yatra in August

THE PK GAMEPLAN

- **Rock the Casbah:** PK's charges against senior BJP-JD(U) leaders on the eve of polls keep him in the headlines, puncture NDA image
- **Rising giant:** PK's national profile, narrative-setting skill, expanding grassroots network are now real threats
- **Fracture binary:** Contesting all 243 assembly seats to disrupt RJD-JD(U) duopoly
- **Spoiler effect:** 7–10% vote swing towards Jan Suraaj can tilt result in many seats

Choudhary to "come clean", as has former Union minister Raj Kumar Singh, who has asked his BJP colleagues in the dock to respond with counter-proof. Yet, CM Nitish Kumar has been conspicuous by his silence, a restraint that is striking, given the *sushaasan* image he has cultivated all these years.

For now, these are allegations, unproven in a court of law, but impossible to ignore in the court of public opinion. They have also cast a shadow on the narrative the NDA has carefully cultivated—of its government being comparatively clean unlike the 'jungle raj' of Lalu Yadav and his party Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD). PK is out to puncture this very balloon, while presenting himself as an exemplar of financial transparency. At the same press conference, he revealed that he had earned Rs 241 crore over the past three years from consultancy work and that "every rupee is accounted for". PK also let it be known that he channels his own funds into his Jan Suraaj Party.

PARTY AMBITIONS

Kishor has been explicit about the fledgling Jan Suraaj's ambitions. In a state where many contests are decided by wafer-thin margins, the projected swing of 7–10 per cent towards him can be decisive. In the 2020 assembly election, 35 of the 243 seats were decided by margins of less than 3,000 votes, and 52 others by margins of under 5,000.

In such a finely balanced contest, Kishor's claim that Jan Suraaj will contest all 243 seats carries import.